

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Ratings derived from search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ additional sites — measuring public discussion, not lines of code.

Methodology

Updated monthly
since 2001

Tracks skilled
engineers, training
courses & vendors

Index ≠ "best"
language ranking

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Python #1

21.25%

-2.59 pp YoY

C #2 ↑

11.55%

+2.02 pp YoY

Top 4 Share

48.97%

of total index

Rank '26	Rank '25	Language	Rating	YoY Δ
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

▲ GAINERS			
Perl	24th → 11th	+13 spots	+1.05%
R	16th → 9th	+7 spots	+0.94%
Swift	26th → 20th	+6 spots	+0.44%
C	4th → 2nd	+2 spots	+2.02%
C#	5th → 5th	held	+1.49%

▼ LOSERS			
Go	7th → 16th	-9 spots	-1.49%
C++	2nd → 3rd	-1 spot	-2.90%
Java	3rd → 4th	-1 spot	-2.37%
Python	1st → 1st	held	-2.59%
PHP	13th → 18th	-5 spots	-0.25%

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	16	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	19	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

Python

Unranked → #1 in 25 years

C

Only language top-2 all 9 snapshots

Java

Dominated 2005–2018, now #4

Lisp

#2 in 1986, now #26

Historical trend 2002–2026: Python surged above 25% after 2018 (now 21.25%); Java fell from 25%+ dominance to under 8%; JavaScript has never exceeded ~5% despite web ubiquity.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language



Python: 6 wins (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024) · C# back-to-back: 2023 & 2025 · Go's 2016 win preceded its sharpest decline (now #16)

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Python — Invest but Diversify

Dominant at 21.25% and 6× Language of the Year. However, its -2.59 pp YoY drop is the steepest among the top 5. Python hiring and training pipelines remain essential, but watch for momentum shifts toward C.

C Resurgence — Revisit Systems Investment

C climbed from 4th to 2nd with +2.02 pp — the largest gain in the index. Embedded systems, OS kernels, and performance-critical services may benefit from renewed C skills investment.

Go's Sharp Decline — Re-evaluate Bets

Go dropped 9 positions (7th → 16th, -1.49 pp). Cloud/DevOps teams that bet heavily on Go should monitor whether Rust (#14, +0.09%) is displacing it in the systems/services space.

Legacy Revival — Perl, R, Fortran Are Not Dead

Perl (+13 spots), R (+7 spots), and Fortran (#13) show strong persistence. Scientific computing, bioinformatics, and data-engineering teams need specialist skills, not just Python replacements.

Concentration Risk — Top 4 Own Half the Index

Python + C + C++ + Java = 48.97%. When dominant languages shift, the ripple is large. Ensure hiring and upskilling strategies are not solely indexed to the top 2 languages.